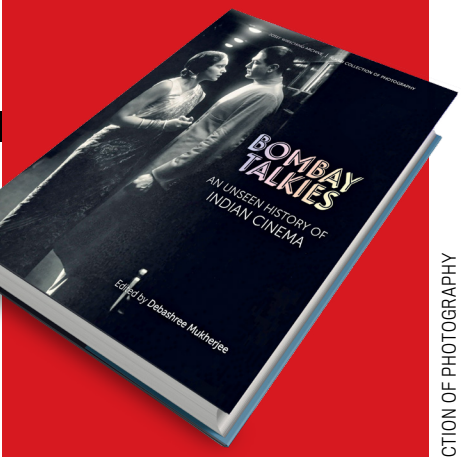


BOMBAY TALKIES
An Unseen History of Indian Cinema
Edited by Debashree Mukherjee
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Second World War, which resulted in a forced hiatus, and how the Nazification of Germany played a role in Josef's resolve to move and make a home in India. "Bombay Talkies offered Wirsching the professional status and creative freedom that was not possible in Germany's crowded and politicised film scene." It further helped that the studio was focused on making socially relevant dramas with a progressive streak.

Essays by Majumdar, Sudhir Mahadevan and Rachel Dwyer analyse Wirsching's work in India, which began as early as 1925 with *The Light of Asia*, as well as the impact he had on Indian cinematography, particularly through his mentoring of camera and lighting crews in the studio. "Bombay cinema from the 1930s to the 1950s reveals a strong influence of German Expressionism, and Josef Wirsching played a pioneering role in popularising this stylised film form," says Mukherjee. "The Expressionist vocabulary is strongly imprinted in Wirsching's lighting designs and compositions." They are most visible in Bombay Talkies' debut film, *Jawani Ki Hawa*, and later in *Mahal* (1949), a gothic thriller starring Madhubala and Kumar. Wirsching's other credits include *Dil Apna Aur Preet Parai* (1960) and the classic *Pakeezah* (1972). He died before *Pakeezah's* filming was completed in 1967, but is believed to have been largely responsible for the camerawork on the film's iconic songs "Inhi Logo Ne", "Chalte Chalte" and "Thare Rahiyo".

THE COLLECTION HAS MANY STILLS BUT IT'S BEHIND-THE-SCENES SHOTS AND CANDIDS THAT STAND OUT

Mahadevan writes about the "remarkable diversity" of Wirsching's collection, which includes genres of photography, be it images taken during location scouting or production of films. It's the latter that history buffs are likely to study to get a sense of filmmaking and the mood on sets in the days of yore. One sees a picture of a light assistant resting against a reflector, another of Rani lighting a cigarette during a break, and many of Wirsching at work. Dwyer highlights Wirsching's role in making the faces of Rani, Madhubala and Meena Kumari iconic through the use of light and shadow.

For Mukherjee, it's a regret that despite the fame of Bombay Talkies studio, the films made by it are still unseen by many. This book, she hopes, will make readers seek out those films and "shake some of our misconceptions about our shared cinematic past". ■

Suhani Singh



SUPRIYA KANTAK

sends ripples through the family. The script's exploration of what constitutes a family and home now resonated with Tagore, who herself grew up in a joint family. "The more pillars in your life, the more sustenance you get," she says. "So much is lost in a nuclear family. Today's pace of living doesn't allow us to be together."

The multi-generational family drama also stars Manoj Bajpayee as Kusum's eldest son. For Bajpayee, working with Tagore was an opportunity to learn from a legend, much like he did with Amitabh Bachchan in the 2001 film *Aks*.

"What is so great about these people is that they are observers of time and of self. She has seen the industry changing and the definition of hero and heroine changing, but you don't take time to adapt," he says. "If you are self-obsessed and living in past glory, then it becomes difficult for you to come out of it and work with the new generation."

The mood in a room still shifts when Tagore, who is 78, walks in. On a recent February afternoon at Hyatt Centric hotel in Mumbai, Tagore, dressed in a floral print sari with her grey hair cut short, had everyone gushing. The awe and respect were evident on the faces of Chittale and Bajpayee, too. "She has this childlike curiosity," says Chittella. The actress beamed as Bajpayee said his career's highlight was to waltz with her in a scene.

Making her OTT debut, Tagore hopes that *Gulmohar* will connect with families. "You can make your islands in your home also. Even if you're not physically together, if the bond is there and you are close to each other, you can still be together. The need is not to talk so much but to hear each other". ■

Suhani Singh